

Indonesia: Gibran ruling tests Prabowo-Jokowi ties

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【メール原文】

Indonesia's Constitutional Court ruling is a partial reprieve for the vice president, but tensions remain between Prabowo and Jokowi.|||||||

Quick take

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Indonesia: Prabowo-Jokowi relations a watchpoint despite Gibran court ruling

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What Happened

The Constitutional Court dismissed a case filed by a former vice minister of law and backed by retired military officers that sought to invalidate the 2024 election of Gibran Rakabuming Raka—son of former president Joko Widodo (Jokowi)—as vice president. The petitioners alleged Gibran had not gained a high-school equivalent qualification while living overseas.

Our Take

Court's decision a partial reprieve for Gibran. The court ruled that it could not find convincing evidence that Gibran held a foreign diploma equivalent to a high-school qualification, an eligibility requirement to run for vice president. However, it dismissed the case because it determined the petitioners lacked legal standing. The court also noted that it falls to the competent authorities under the constitution to determine the validity and fulfilment of eligibility requirements. This means Gibran could potentially face an impeachment threat in parliament.

The court ruling also leaves the question hanging of whether Gibran can run for president in 2029 unless he can resolve the education qualification issue beforehand. The vice president holds limited political power in Indonesia and Gibran has been even weaker than most office holders, but his fate plays into broader speculation about the state of relations between President Prabowo Subianto and Jokowi, whose support propelled Prabowo to the top job. As things stand, it would be difficult for Gibran to beat Prabowo in 2029 even if he can run.

The Constitutional Court retains relative independence from the executive. While the extent of Prabowo's support (or not) for the case against Gibran is unclear, at the very least it seems unlikely that former military officers would petition against the vice president if they knew ex-general Prabowo was against the idea. It is likely, though, that some of Prabowo's allies are opposed to Gibran, with others more supportive. The dismissal of the case therefore suggests the court retains relative independence at a time of broader concerns about institutional erosion. Previous court decisions, such as striking down proposed changes to election laws, indicate the body acts as one of the few checks on Prabowo's

concentration of political power.

Prabowo's recent cabinet reshuffle further strains ties with Jokowi. Prabowo replaced police chief Listyo Sigit Prabowo—appointed by Jokowi in 2021—with Suyudi Ario Seto as part of a wider recent reshuffle of his cabinet and senior officials. Prabowo also swapped another Jokowi-linked figure, Coordinating Minister for Human Development and Culture Pratikno, with his ally Sugiono (previously foreign minister). The changes point to a shift toward an even more Prabowo-dominant administration, although they do not yet amount to an open break with Jokowi. Notably, the president moved Listyo to head the Presidential Staff Office rather than push him out completely. Other cabinet changes have similarly repositioned several Jokowi-linked figures while keeping them within the government.

For investors, the key risk is that growing friction between the two camps could increase policy uncertainty, especially if political competition rises ahead of the 2029 election. This could affect appointments, coalition dynamics, or the implementation of Prabowo's economic agenda.

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